# Seven Days, Twenty-Eight Days, and the Number 61: The Road from the Ballot to a Government

**Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren — Torah scholar, researcher and writer Jerusalem, 31 October 2026**

The ballots have been counted. Now comes the part of Israeli democracy that happens in quiet rooms rather than at polling stations. This week, the lists that passed the threshold for the 26th Knesset begin preparing to sit with President Isaac Herzog and tell him whom they recommend to form the next government.

It is worth slowing down to understand what that means, because the next few weeks will be full of noise. Knowing the rules helps us hear the noise for what it is.

## What the preliminary results say

The Central Elections Committee's results page shows votes and percentages, not seats. Its preliminary count, as of 30 October 2026, gives these shares of valid votes to the eleven lists above the threshold:

- Likud: 20.52 percent (1,167,458 votes)
- Yashar!: 16.05 percent (913,502)
- Together (B'Yachad): 9.34 percent (531,476)
- Joint List: 8.79 percent (500,147)
- The Democrats: 6.44 percent (366,352)
- Yisrael Beytenu: 5.93 percent (337,413)
- Ra'am: 5.93 percent (337,253)
- Otzma Yehudit: 5.74 percent (326,624)
- United Torah Judaism: 5.49 percent (312,604)
- Shas: 5.26 percent (299,506)
- Religious Zionism: 5.10 percent (290,451)

Of 7,331,981 eligible voters, 5,716,673 votes were counted, about 78 percent, and 5,690,685 of them were valid. The 3.25 percent threshold comes to about 184,947 valid votes. Every other list fell below it.

These figures are preliminary, per the CEC as of 30 October, and remain subject to change. Final seat totals will be published in the Official Records by Wednesday, 4 November 2026,

and those are the results the President will work from. The new Knesset is slated to be sworn in on Tuesday, 10 November 2026.

## What the consultations are

Israelis do not vote for a prime minister. We vote for lists, and the lists become Knesset factions. The President's job is to find the member of Knesset with the best chance of building a government that the Knesset will approve.

The rules come from Basic Law: The Government. Section 7 says that once a new government must be formed, the President, "after consulting the representatives of the Parliamentary Groups," assigns the task to a member of Knesset who has agreed to take it on. When the consultations happen before the new Knesset has convened, as they likely will this time, the President consults the representatives of the lists that will sit in it.

In practice, each faction sends a delegation to the President's Residence. Each one says whom it recommends, or that it recommends no one. The meetings are usually broadcast, and they are the first time we hear, on the record, where every party stands after the vote.

## The clock

The Basic Law sets the clock, and the clock matters.

First, seven days. The President must assign the task "within seven days from the publication of the election results." If the results go to the President on 4 November 2026, that points to a decision by about 11 November 2026.

Second, twenty-eight days. Under Section 8, the member of Knesset who gets the task has 28 days to form a government. The President may extend this "by additional periods, as long as all together they shall not exceed 14 days." So the first candidate has up to 42 days in all.

Third, if that fails. Under Section 9, if the candidate cannot form a government in time, the President has three days either to give the task to another member of Knesset or to tell the Speaker that he sees no way to form a government. A second candidate gets 28 days, and the law gives no extension for that round.

Fourth, the Knesset itself. Under Section 10, if that round also fails, a majority of members of Knesset may ask the President in writing, within 21 days, to give the task to a specific member who has agreed in writing. If that does not produce a government either, the Basic Law treats the Knesset as dispersed, and Israel goes back to elections.

That is a long road. It is also a road with exits, and every party knows exactly where they are.

## Why 61 matters

A government needs the confidence of the Knesset, and a stable one needs 61 of the 120 seats.

Seats are shared out in proportion to valid votes among the lists that pass the threshold, so the preliminary shares give a sense of the field but not the final number for any party. The final seat count will show whether any bloc reaches 61.

If neither large camp gets there on its own, the arithmetic would have to run through one of three doors: a party crossing from one camp to the other, a government that depends in some way on one or both Arab-led lists, or some form of broad or unity arrangement between large parties that spent the campaign running against each other.

Each door would have a lock. Several party leaders said during the campaign and since, on the record, whom they will not sit with. Those statements are part of what the President will weigh when he asks the simple question that the consultations come down to: who can actually get to 61?

Two further points are worth holding onto. First, the President is not bound to choose the leader of the largest party, though the person with the most recommendations usually gets the first chance. Second, a recommendation is not a coalition. A faction can recommend a candidate and still drive a very hard bargain afterwards.

## An open question, handled with care

Hanging over all of this is the investigation the Central Elections Committee chairman asked the Shin Bet to open into suspected foreign interference. According to reports, the suspicions concern money from Qatar, which Doha has categorically denied. The committee has said, with the approval of its chairman, Justice Noam Sohlberg, that the investigation will not affect the final results submitted to the President and does not concern any particular community. The Shin Bet said the inquiry is "focused and limited" and asked the public to avoid speculation about its substance.

So the honest position for now is a question, not a conclusion. What will the investigation find, and will its findings matter to anyone's choices in the President's Residence? We do not know yet. Until we do, the Torah's standard of guarding our speech applies to all of us, and especially to those of us who write. No community and no person should be treated as guilty because of a report about an inquiry that has not finished.

## Why it matters

There is something steadying in a process with clear rules. Elections can feel like a storm. The Basic Law turns the storm into a calendar: seven days, twenty-eight days, fourteen more, three days, another twenty-eight, twenty-one.

Our tradition knows that a people needs structure to hold its arguments. The consultations are a small piece of that structure. They make every party say out loud, in front of the whole country, what it really wants. Whatever we each hope the outcome will be, that is worth watching closely, and worth explaining to one another with patience and respect.

*Preliminary results: Central Elections Committee, national results page (votes26.bechirot.gov.il), as of 30 October 2026; final seat totals by 4 November 2026. Legal text: Basic Law: The Government (Knesset English translation).*

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